



By **Kalika Bali**

AN AI **FOR BHARAT**

MOVING PAST ENGLISH-FIRST SYSTEMS, INDIA IS CREATING MULTILINGUAL, CONTEXT-AWARE AI TO ASSIST, PROTECT AND EMPOWER COMMUNITIES

In **rural Rajasthan's Udaipur district, an Accredited Social Health Activist (ASHA)** notices that a newborn's weight has barely changed over several weeks. She has followed protocol. The mother insists the child is feeding regularly. There are no obvious warning signs. Still, something feels off—and she is unsure what to check next.

Instead of scrolling through manuals or calling a supervisor who may not be reachable, the ASHA worker opens WhatsApp and speaks into her phone in Hindi, describing the situation aloud: the feeding pattern, the age of the child, the missed weight gain. She is not typing. She is talking, the way she always does.

The response comes back—spoken, not written—guiding her through possible reasons for stagnant weight gain and suggesting what to monitor before the next visit. The assistant she is speaking to is ASHABot, developed at Microsoft Research India and deployed with partners working on the ground. It is not a futuristic demo. It is an early glimpse of how artificial intelligence is beginning to meet people where they are—through voice, local language and context, rather than English text alone.

This moment captures a quiet but consequential shift in India's AI journey. The question is no longer whether India will use AI, but whose language, whose knowledge and whose realities these systems will recognise.

India is home to 22 scheduled languages, hundreds of dialects and deeply fluid multilingual practices. Most Indians code-switch effortlessly, blending languages, registers and idioms within a single conversation. Language here is not merely a communication tool; it is a marker of identity, authority and access. That is why language in India is not a preference setting. It is a gatekeeper.

The last decade's Digital India push built the rails—identity, payments, connectivity. But infrastructure alone does not guarantee access. Vernacular AI determines who can actually step onto the platform. A system that works flawlessly in English but falters in Indian languages quietly reproduces exclusion at scale.

Much of today's multilingual AI rests on a seductive assumption: build powerful English models and trans-

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